

IF GOD IS GOOD

FAITH IN THE MIDST OF SUFFERING AND EVIL

Randy Alcorn | Key Ideas, Arguments, and Foundations

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THE BIG QUESTION

If there is a God and if He is good, truly good, and if He is all-powerful, meaning He can do anything, then *why is the world such a slaughterhouse?* Why is there so much pain?

"This is the ultimate stumbling block. It is the reason people walk away from faith, and the reason some people never even approach it in the first place."

1 THE WEIGHT OF THE QUESTION

A Universal and Agonizing Dilemma

- ◆ The problem of evil is the heaviest question humanity has ever asked.
- ◆ It has launched a thousand ships of philosophy and sunk most of them.
- ◆ It is not just an intellectual puzzle—it is a real and emotional crisis for many people.
- ◆ It causes some to walk away from faith and keeps others from ever approaching it.



2 TWO PROBLEMS OF EVIL

A Critical Distinction

LOGICAL PROBLEM OF EVIL

- ◆ An intellectual or philosophical puzzle.
- ◆ Debated in a university philosophy hall with a cup of coffee.
- ◆ Abstract and theoretical.
- ◆ Asks: Can God be both good and all-powerful if evil exists?
- ◆ Interesting and important, but often emotionally detached.

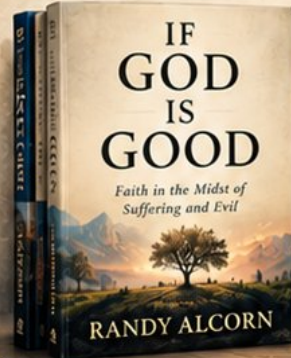
EMOTIONAL PROBLEM OF EVIL

- ◆ A personal and existential crisis.
- ◆ Occurs when suffering hits close to home—e.g., a 2 a.m. phone call, a diagnosis, a child's suffering.
- ◆ Not an abstract debate, but lived reality.
- ◆ The answers that satisfy philosophers often offer zero comfort to the sufferer.
- ◆ This is where the rubber meets the road.

We must navigate both lanes: the logical and the emotional.

3 THE AUTHOR AND THE BOOK

Randy Alcorn – A Comprehensive Examination



- ◆ This is not a short inspirational pamphlet.
- ◆ It is a comprehensive, heavyweight treatment of the entire theology of suffering.
- ◆ Randy Alcorn (1954 –) is a prolific Christian author known for his work on heaven, suffering, and the Christian life.
- ◆ His goal: to show that faith can not only survive the worst tragedies imaginable, but actually thrive within them.

4 OUR ROADMAP

How the Book and Our Discussion Unfold

1	The Nature of the Problem	What is the problem of evil and why is it so powerful?
2	How Different Worldviews Handle It	Christians aren't the only ones with a problem.
3	The Theology	Free will, the origins of evil, and key doctrines.
4	The Practical	How people actually find purpose in the middle of their pain.

5 A REAL-LIFE EXAMPLE

Jim Harrell and the Paradox of Suffering



- ◆ Randy Alcorn begins with the story of his friend Jim Harrell.
- ◆ Jim was a successful businessman, strong, athletic, with a great family—"living the dream."
- ◆ In 2003, he was diagnosed with ALS (Lou Gehrig's disease), a horrific, degenerative neurological disease.
- ◆ ALS is a prison: the brain stays sharp and lucid, but the body shuts down bit by bit.
- ◆ Jim eventually lost all movement below his neck.
- ◆ He could not hug his wife, could not feed himself, and had to lie there and watch his body deteriorate.
- ◆ Yet Jim Harrell called those years with ALS *"the most significant, the most meaningful years of my entire life."*

The paradox: How can someone in such extreme suffering say that? This paradox frames Alcorn's entire argument.

6 KEY TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

Essential Concepts for the Discussion

Term	Definition (as used in the discussion)
Problem of Evil	The challenge of reconciling the existence of evil and suffering with a good, all-powerful God.
Logical Problem of Evil	An intellectual, philosophical question about whether God's goodness and sovereignty are logically compatible with evil.
Emotional Problem of Evil	The personal, existential crisis that arises when suffering is experienced firsthand.
Suffering	Physical, emotional, or psychological pain and loss.
Evil	Moral evil (sinful actions) and natural evil (natural disasters, disease, etc.).
Theodicy	A defense of God's goodness and justice in the face of evil.
Free Will	The God-given ability to choose, which plays a key role in understanding the origin of moral evil.
Purpose in Suffering	The belief that God can bring meaning and good even through severe trials.

7 WHY THIS MATTERS



Shapes our view of God.



Influences whether people embrace or reject faith.



Affects how we respond to our own suffering and the suffering of others.



Gets to the heart of the Christian message and the character of God.



Has real implications for life, hope, and eternity.

IF GOD IS GOOD

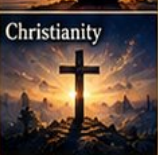
FAITH IN THE MIDST OF SUFFERING AND EVIL

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1 HOW DIFFERENT WORLDVIEWS HANDLE EVIL

Alcorn argues that Christians are not the only ones with a problem. Every worldview must account for evil, suffering, and injustice.

Worldview	Core Claim	How It Handles Evil	Key Problems
 Atheism (Physicalism)	Only matter exists. No God.	Evil is a natural byproduct of an impersonal universe (evolution, chance, physical laws).	- No objective moral standards (evil is just preference). - Suffering has no ultimate meaning. - Justice is an illusion.
 Pantheism	God and the universe are one.	Evil is an illusion (maya) or a necessary part of the whole.	- Real suffering is denied. - Morality is relative. - No personal God who cares.
 Dualism	Two equal forces: good vs. evil.	Evil comes from an independent evil force.	- Cannot explain which force ultimately wins. - Evil is never fully conquered. - Not supported by Scripture.
 Deism	God created the world but does not intervene.	Evil exists because God is distant and does not interfere.	- Contradicts Scripture's depiction of an active God. - Offers no hope, comfort, or ultimate justice.
 Eastern Religions	Suffering is part of karma and the cycle of reincarnation.	Evil results from past actions; the goal is escape through enlightenment.	- Places blame on the victim. - No assurance of final justice. - Cannot explain innocent suffering (e.g., children).
 Christianity	One good, sovereign, personal God.	Evil entered through a real historical fall; God permits it for a greater purpose and will ultimately end it.	- Must explain why a good God permits suffering. - Yet uniquely offers real hope, purpose, and final justice.

2 THE LOGICAL ARGUMENTS

Classic Arguments and Christian Responses

THE INCONSISTENCY ARGUMENT



If God is all-powerful and all-good, then evil should not exist. But evil exists. Therefore, God is either not all-powerful, not all-good, or does not exist.

Christian Response

- False dilemma.
- It assumes we know all possible reasons God might permit evil.
- Our limited perspective cannot rule out greater goods.

THE EVIDENTIAL ARGUMENT



The amount and intensity of evil (e.g., genocides, natural disasters, child suffering) is inconsistent with a good God.

Christian Response

- Evil is real and horrific.
- Yet it is not ultimately disproportionate to God's greater purposes.
- We lack the full picture now (Rom 8:18).

THE PROBABILISTIC ARGUMENT



A perfectly good and powerful God would prevent most evil. The extent of evil makes God's existence highly improbable.

Christian Response

- Probability is not certainty.
- We must consider long-term purposes, free will, and a future, eternal perspective.
- Some evils may be necessary for greater goods.

THE HIDDENNESS ARGUMENT



If God is good, he would make his existence more obvious. The fact that many sincere people do not believe suggests God is hidden and therefore not good.

Christian Response

- God is not hidden to all.
- A measure of hiddenness preserves genuine freedom.
- People suppress the truth (Rom 1:18–20).
- God reveals himself through creation, conscience, and Christ.

3 KEY DISTINCTIONS

Important Concepts for Understanding Alcorn's Approach

PERMISSION VS. CAUSATION

God does not cause evil, but he permits it for greater purposes.

- God remains holy and good.
- Permission is not indifference.

GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY VS. HUMAN RESPONSIBILITY

God is sovereign over all things, yet humans are morally responsible for their choices.

- Both truths are taught in Scripture.
- They are complementary, not contradictory.

TEMPORAL VS. ETERNAL PERSPECTIVE

Suffering looks senseless in the short term, but God works all things for a greater, eternal purpose (Rom 8:18, 28).

- We see the present chapter.
- God sees the whole story.

GREATER GOOD DEFENSE

God permits some evil because it is necessary for a greater good that could not otherwise be achieved.

- Examples: free will, genuine love, moral character, the display of God's justice and mercy.

4 BIBLICAL FOUNDATION

Key Scriptures on God, Evil, and Suffering

ROMANS 8:18, 28

"For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed... And we know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose." (ESV)

ISAIAH 55:8–9

"For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the LORD. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways and my thoughts than your thoughts." (ESV)

JOB 42:1–5

"I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted... I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you." (ESV)

1 PETER 1:6–7

"In this you rejoice, though now for a little while, if necessary, you have been grieved by various trials, so that the tested genuineness of your faith—more precious than gold that perishes though it is tested by fire—may be found to result in praise and glory and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ." (ESV)

5 WHY THE CHRISTIAN VIEW IS UNIQUE

Alcorn's Key Insight: Christianity uniquely combines honest realism about evil with a reasonable, hope-filled answer.

EVIL IS REAL



Christianity does not minimize suffering. It acknowledges the depth of evil.

GOD IS GOOD AND SOVEREIGN



God remains perfectly good, just, and in control.

A REAL SOLUTION



The cross shows God entering our suffering and defeating evil through Jesus Christ.

A FUTURE HOPE



Evil will be fully ended. God will make all things new (Rev 21:1–5).

MEANING NOW



Suffering can have real purpose in God's redemptive plan.

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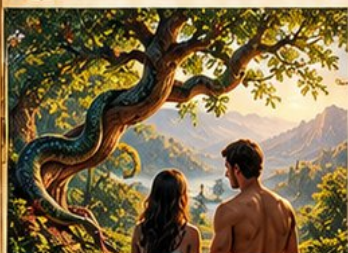
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1 THE ORIGIN OF EVIL

How Evil Entered God's Good Creation



- ♦ God created a very good world (Gen 1:31).
- ♦ Evil entered through the real rebellion of Satan and the sin of humanity (Gen 3).
- ♦ Evil is not part of God's nature; it is a corruption of what God created.
- ♦ Sin brought a fractured world—spiritual, moral, and physical brokenness (Rom 8:20–22).

KEY POINTS

- ♦ Evil is a real historical intrusion, not a necessary part of creation.
- ♦ Satan is a real personal being who rebelled (Isa 14:12–15; Ezek 28:12–17).
- ♦ Humanity freely joined in rebellion (Gen 3).

"For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory that is to be revealed to us."

Romans 8:18 (ESV)

2 FREE WILL AND REAL LOVE

Why God Allows the Possibility of Evil

- ♦ Alcorn argues that a world with genuine free will is necessary for real love, moral responsibility, and meaningful relationships.
- ♦ Love, obedience, and worship that are forced have no real value.
- ♦ Freedom necessarily carries the possibility of rejection, rebellion, and evil.
- ♦ A world of "free creatures" is a higher good than a world of robots.



FREE WILL: WHAT IT DOES AND DOES NOT MEAN

IT DOES MEAN:

- ✓ Real choices.
- ✓ Genuine love, faith, and obedience.
- ✓ Moral responsibility.
- ✓ A world of authentic people, not robots.

IT DOES NOT MEAN:

- ✗ God loses control.
- ✗ God is surprised by human choices.
- ✗ Human freedom is absolute or unlimited.
- ✗ God cannot accomplish His purposes.

3 GOD'S SOVEREIGNTY AND HUMAN FREEDOM

A Mystery, Not a Contradiction



- ♦ Alcorn affirms both God's sovereignty and real human responsibility.
- ♦ These are complementary truths taught in Scripture (e.g., Acts 2:23; Phil 2:12–13).
- ♦ God works through human choices—good and evil—to accomplish His purposes.
- ♦ We do not fully understand how God's sovereignty and human freedom fit together, but both are clearly taught.

4 THE CROSS: GOD SUFFERS WITH US

The Central Answer to the Emotional Problem of Evil



- ♦ The cross shows that God is not distant from suffering—He enters into it (John 1:14).
- ♦ Jesus experienced real human pain, betrayal, and injustice (Isa 53).
- ♦ The cross reveals both the horror of evil and the depth of God's love (Rom 5:8).
- ♦ God can bring good out of evil without minimizing the evil (Gen 50:20).

"But God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Romans 5:8 (ESV)

5 PURPOSES OF SUFFERING

How God Uses Suffering for Good

PURPOSE	DESCRIPTION	KEY SCRIPTURES
CONFORMITY TO CHRIST	Suffering shapes us to be more like Jesus.	Rom 8:28–29 2 Cor 3:17–18
DEEPER DEPENDENCE	It drives us to rely on God, not ourselves.	2 Cor 1:8–11 Ps 34:18
GREATER COMPASSION	It enables us to comfort others with the comfort we receive.	2 Cor 1:3–4
TESTIMONY	It can display God's grace to a watching world.	1 Pet 2:12
ETERNAL PERSPECTIVE	Suffering reminds us this world is not our home.	2 Cor 4:17–18 Heb 11:13–16
GLORY TO GOD	Ultimately, God is glorified as He brings good from evil.	John 11:4 Rom 8:28

6 DIFFERENT KINDS OF SUFFERING

Not All Suffering Is the Same

NATURAL EVIL	MORAL EVIL	SUFFERING FOR RIGHTEOUSNESS
Suffering from natural disasters, disease, and the fallen creation.	Suffering caused by the sinful actions of people (e.g., abuse, war, injustice).	Suffering because of faith in Christ and obedience to God's Word.
♦ Result of a broken world (Rom 8:20–22). ♦ Not usually the result of a specific personal sin.	♦ Comes from human rebellion. ♦ God can bring good even from wicked acts. Gen 50:20	♦ Part of the Christian life (2 Tim 3:12). ♦ Can produce eternal reward (1 Pet 4:12–16).

7 EITHER WAY, GOD IS GOOD

Trust in the Tension



- ♦ We may not understand why in this life, but we can trust God's character.
- ♦ God is working all things for His purposes (Rom 8:28).
- ♦ Suffering is not meaningless.
- ♦ Our present pain is temporary compared to the coming glory (2 Cor 4:17–18).

"We know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose."

Romans 8:28 (ESV)

8 KEY TAKEAWAYS FROM THIS SECTION

Foundations for a Faith That Endures

- 1 Evil is real, but it is not ultimate; it is an intrusion into a good creation.
- 2 Genuine free will is necessary for real love and moral responsibility.
- 3 God is sovereign and can accomplish His purposes even through evil.
- 4 The cross shows that God suffers with us and is for us.
- 5 God uses suffering for many good purposes, even when we do not see them.
- 6 Not all suffering is the same; we must think carefully about its source.
- 7 We can trust God's goodness even when we do not understand His ways.

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1 ETERNITY CHANGES EVERYTHING

Our Present Suffering Is Not the Final Chapter

- Alcorn argues that a right view of eternity is essential for making sense of suffering.
- This world is temporary; it is not our home (2 Cor 4:17–18).
- God will one day renew all things and remove every trace of evil, pain, and death (Rev 21:1–5).
- Our eternal future gives present suffering meaning and perspective.
- Earthly suffering, even the worst, is temporary compared to the eternal weight of glory (2 Cor 4:17).



“He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away.”
Revelation 21:4 (ESV)

2 THE NATURE OF OUR FUTURE HOPE

A Real, Bodily, Renewed Creation

A Renewed Creation		Not escaping the world, but the restoration of creation.	Rev 21:1–5 Isa 65:17–25
Resurrection Bodies		We will be bodily resurrected and free from pain, sickness, and death.	1 Cor 15:42–44 Phil 3:20–21
No More Evil		Evil, sin, and death will be completely defeated.	Rev 21:4 1 Cor 15:26
Perfect Relationships		We will be restored with God and with one another.	Rev 21:3 1 Cor 13:12
Purpose Fulfilled		Our present faithfulness participates in God’s eternal purposes.	Matt 25:21 Rev 22:3–5

3 COMMON OBJECTIONS AND ALCORN’S RESPONSES

Thoughtful Answers to Tough Questions

Objection	Alcorn’s Response
“A good God wouldn’t allow any suffering.”	Suffering can be a necessary part of a world with free creatures, real love, and meaningful moral choices.
“Evil disproves God’s existence.”	Every worldview must account for evil. No worldview provides a complete or satisfying answer.
“Some suffering seems pointless and excessive.”	We do not always see the purpose now, but God is sovereign and nothing is wasted (Rom 8:28).
“Why do children suffer?”	This is especially tragic. Alcorn points to the fall, a broken world, and God’s future justice and redemption.
“If God can stop evil, why doesn’t He?”	He has morally sufficient reasons, including free will, greater goods, and His redemptive plan.
“Suffering makes faith unreasonable.”	Suffering can deepen faith, produce perseverance, and display the reality of God’s grace.
“A loving God would end it now.”	He will. Until then, He works through suffering to accomplish eternal purposes.

4 HOW TO FIND PURPOSE IN THE MIDST OF PAIN

Practical Ways to Respond

	1. Turn to God	- Bring your pain honestly to God. - Lament is a biblical response (Psalms). - God is near to the brokenhearted (Ps 34:18).
	2. Trust His Character	- Remember who God is—good, sovereign, wise, and loving. - Hold to His promises when feelings say otherwise.
	3. Rely on His People	- Allow others to walk with you. - Suffering is not meant to be faced alone (Gal 6:2; Heb 10:24–25).
	4. Look for Opportunities	- Suffering can open doors for ministry, compassion, and witness. - Our testimony can point others to Christ (2 Cor 1:3–4).
	5. Keep an Eternal Perspective	- You are not home yet. - Present suffering is temporary compared to the coming glory (2 Cor 4:17–18).
	6. Persevere in Faith	- Suffering produces endurance, character, and hope (Rom 5:3–5). - Keep trusting, even when you do not understand.

5 THE TRANSFORMING POWER OF SUFFERING

How God Uses Suffering in Our Lives

- Suffering is not meaningless; God can use it for real, lasting good (Rom 8:28).
- It can deepen our dependence on God.
- It can produce Christ-like character (Rom 5:3–5).
- It can open doors for ministry and compassion (2 Cor 1:3–4).
- It can free us from lesser idols and increase our desire for Christ.
- It can display God’s grace and power to others.
- It can prepare us for greater ministry in God’s eternal kingdom.



“We know that for those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose.”
Romans 8:28 (ESV)

6 LIVING FAITHFULLY WHEN SUFFERING CONTINUES

Endurance, Worship, and Witness

	- Continue to trust God’s goodness and sovereignty. - Obey Him even when you do not understand. - Worship remains possible in the midst of pain (Job 1:20–22). - Look for ways to bless and serve others. - Keep your eyes on the coming glory. - Let your life display the reality of a God who is good, even when life is hard.
	<i>“Though he slay me, I will hope in him.”</i> Job 13:15 (ESV)

7 KEY VERSES TO REMEMBER

Anchors for a Faith That Endures

Rom 8:28	2 Cor 4:17–18	Rom 5:3–5	1 Pet 1:6–7	Rev 21:4
“All things work together for good for those who love God ...”	“Our light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory.”	“Suffering produces endurance, character, and hope ...”	“Your faith ... though tested by fire—may be found to result in praise and glory.”	“He will wipe away every tear ... neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain.”

8 THE BIG TAKEAWAY

A Faith That Survives and Thrives

God is good.
Suffering is real.
Evil will end.
Our present pain has purpose.
Eternity makes sense of it all.
Therefore, we can trust, persevere,
and even thrive in the midst of suffering.

